

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

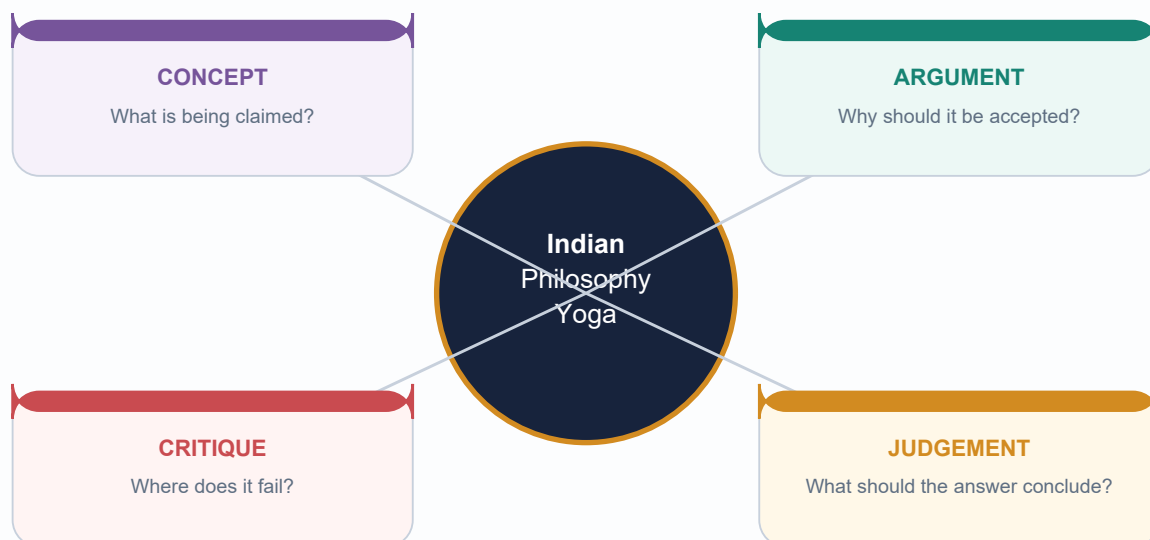
Indian Philosophy: Yoga

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Citta; Cittavrtti; Klesas; Samadhi; Kaivalya.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Yoga chapter (local PDF pp. 233-247); C. D. Sharma, Yoga chapter (printed pp. 157-162); Radhakrishnan, Indian Philosophy Vol. II, Yoga chapter. Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: From Citta-Vrtti to Kaivalya

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Yoga adopts Samkhya's Purusa-Prakriti dualism but supplies a disciplined psychology and practice. The problem is identification with citta's changing forms; the solution is their restraint and discriminative clarity.

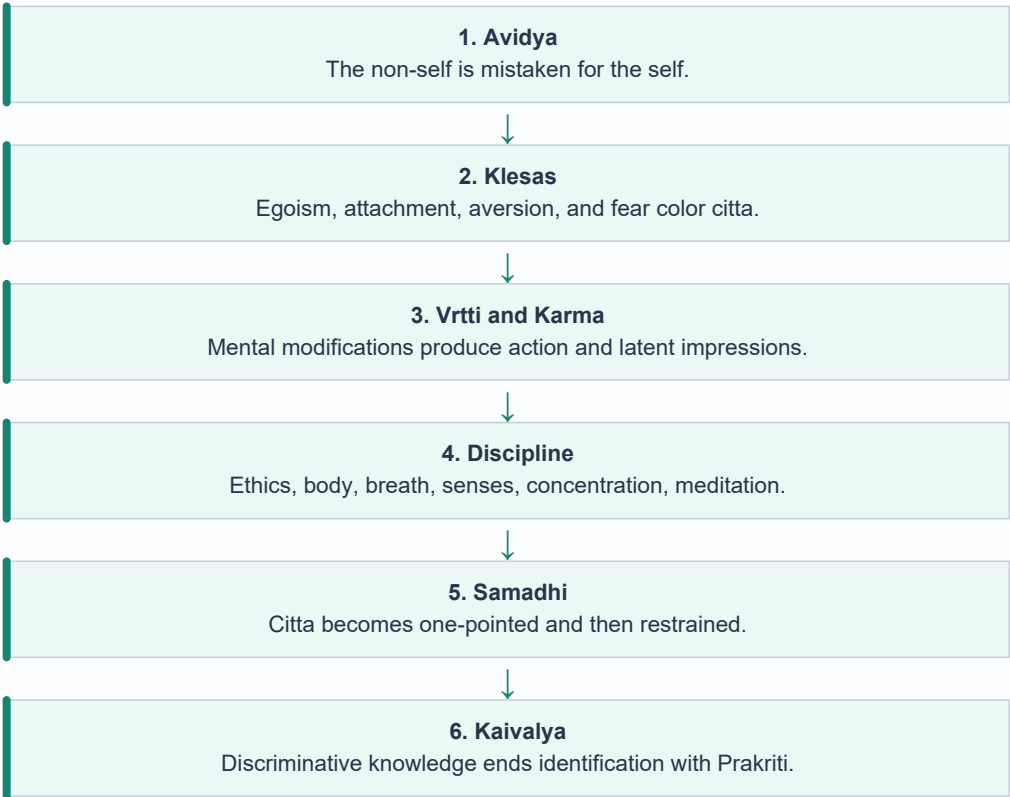
The syllabus names psychological and soteriological concepts rather than the eight limbs explicitly, but the limbs are the mechanism connecting klesa-removal to samadhi and kaivalya.

YOGA MASTER MAP

YOGA IS RESTRAINT OF CITTA'S MODIFICATIONS

Citta The subtle mind-complex that reflects Purusa.	Vrttis Valid cognition, error, conceptual construction, sleep, memory.
Klesas Ignorance, egoism, attachment, aversion, clinging to life.	Practice Abhyasa, vairagya, and the eight limbs.
Samadhi Object-supported absorption develops toward seedless absorption.	Kaivalya Purusa rests isolated from citta and the gunas.

PSYCHOLOGICAL-SOTERIOLOGICAL FLOW



MEMORY HOOK

CITTA -> KLESA -> KARMA -> PRACTICE -> SAMADHI -> KAIVALYA.

CONCEPT LINKS

Yoga Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Citta	Samkhya buddhi-manas-ahamkara	Yoga operationalizes the subtle apparatus.
Nirodha	Buddhist cessation	Compare methods without equating metaphysics.
Isvara-pranidhana	Nyaya creator God	Devotional aid versus cosmic efficient cause.
Kaivalya	Samkhya liberation	Shared goal, different practical emphasis.

MAINS ANGLE

Yoga converts Samkhya metaphysics into a testable discipline of attention, ethics, and disidentification.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 17; connect every term to the problem of reflected consciousness.

HIGH

Technical Terms: Citta, Vrttis, and Klesas

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Citta belongs to Prakriti but appears conscious because it reflects Purusa. Its modifications may be painful or non-painful, yet even valid cognition must eventually be restrained for complete isolation.

KEY DATA

Term	Meaning	Exam Function
Citta	Mind-stuff integrating buddhi, ego, and mind functions.	Locus of vrttis and impressions.
Pramana	Valid cognition.	A vrtti, not final liberation.
Viparyaya	False cognition.	Direct source of error.
Vikalpa	Conceptual construction based on words without corresponding object.	Shows language-shaped modification.
Nidra	Sleep as a modification supported by absence-content.	Sleep is not mere non-cognition.
Smrti	Memory retaining experienced content.	Links impressions with later cognition.
Avidya	Mistaking impermanent, impure, painful, non-self for their opposites.	Root klesa.
Asmita	Identification of seer with instrument of seeing.	Egoic confusion.
Raga / Dvesa	Attachment to pleasure and aversion to pain.	Motivational bondage.
Abhinivesa	Clinging to life.	Deep affliction present even in the learned.

HOW REFLECTION PRODUCES BONDAGE



STATIC THEORY

- **Five citta stages:** restless, dull, distracted, one-pointed, and restrained; only the last two sustain Yoga.
- **Abhyasa:** sustained effort to remain stable in restraint.
- **Vairagya:** freedom from thirst for experienced or described objects.
- **Kriya-yoga:** austerity, self-study, and dedication to Isvara weaken klesas.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Citta is not Purusa.
2. Nirodha is disciplined restraint, not physical destruction of mind.
3. Avidya is the field from which the other klesas develop.

MAINS ANGLE

Yoga's psychology is a theory of misattribution: consciousness is real, but the mental contents it illuminates are not the self.

STUDY LINK

Use the five vrttis and five klesas as separate numbered lists.

HIGH

Eight Limbs, Samadhi, and Isvara

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The eight limbs progressively stabilize conduct, body, breath, senses, and attention. Samadhi is not one undifferentiated trance; Yoga distinguishes object-supported stages from complete seedless restraint.

KEY DATA

Limb / State	Function	Place in Progress
Yama	Non-violence, truth, non-stealing, continence, non-possession.	Ethical restraint.
Niyama	Purity, contentment, austerity, self-study, dedication to Isvara.	Ethical observance.
Asana	Stable and easeful posture.	Bodily steadiness.
Pranayama	Regulation of breath.	Reduces disturbance.
Pratyahara	Withdrawal of senses from objects.	Bridge inward.
Dharana	Fixing attention.	Concentration.
Dhyana	Uninterrupted flow toward the object.	Meditation.
Samadhi	Object alone shines forth.	Absorption.
Samprajnata	Object-supported cognitive absorption.	Subtle vritti remains.
Asamprajnata	Cessation beyond object-supported cognition.	Latent seeds approach exhaustion.

EXTERNAL TO INTERNAL DISCIPLINE**STATIC THEORY**

- **Isvara:** a special Purusa untouched by klesa, karma, maturation, and latent deposit.
- **Role:** dedication to Isvara removes obstacles and supports concentration; the syllabus question is soteriological, not merely theological.
- **Pranava:** Om is the conventional expression associated with Isvara and is contemplated.
- **Siddhis:** extraordinary powers may result from concentration but can distract from liberation.

MEMORY HOOK

Y-N-A-P-P-D-D-S: ethics, body, breath, senses, concentration, meditation, absorption.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The last three limbs together form samyama.
2. Isvara is not simply the Nyaya creator transplanted into Yoga.
3. Samadhi must culminate in discriminative freedom, not attachment to powers.

MAINS ANGLE

The limbs show that liberation is not achieved by cognition alone but by transforming the conditions of cognition.

STUDY LINK

Use the 2022 and 2025 Isvara questions to distinguish nature, method, and role.

HIGH**Kaivalya and Strongest Criticism-Defence**

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Kaivalya is the isolation of Purusa when citta no longer presents itself as the self. Yoga adds practical theism to Samkhya, but this creates questions about whether Isvara is necessary and how mental cessation can yield knowledge.

KEY DATA

Issue	Criticism	Yoga Defence / Qualification
Nirodha paradox	If all vrttis cease, how can discriminative knowledge remain?	Discriminative cognition performs its function and is itself finally transcended.
Isvara's necessity	A special Purusa seems metaphysically idle.	Isvara is a unique practical aid and ideal, not merely another worldly cause.
Dualism	Purusa-citta relation repeats Samkhya's interaction problem.	Reflection explains appearance without real modification of Purusa.
Samadhi verification	Private absorption may not establish metaphysical truth.	Yoga presents disciplined repeatable transformation, though public verification is limited.
Ethical preparation	Moral rules may seem external to knowledge.	They remove agitation and conflict that obstruct concentration.
Kaivalya	Isolation appears negative and world-withdrawing.	It secures freedom from misidentification and suffering, not annihilation.

ASCENT TO KAIVALYA**COMPARISON TABLE**

Issue	Yoga	Contrast
Method	Eight-limbed discipline	Samkhya: emphasis on discrimination
God	Special Purusa and aid	Nyaya: creator and moral governor
Mind	Citta to be restrained	Advaita: mind purified for Brahman-knowledge
Goal	Kaivalya	Aurobindo: transformation of life and nature

MAINS ANGLE

Yoga's strongest contribution is practical psychology; its weakest point is the contested inference from transformed consciousness to dualist metaphysics.

STUDY LINK

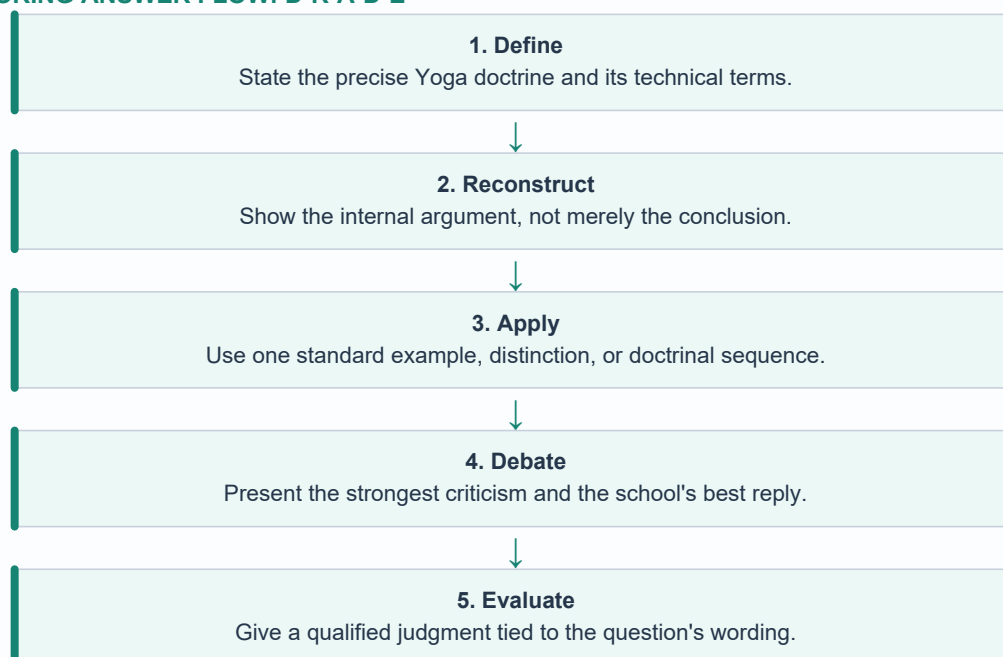
For appraisal questions, assess both efficacy of discipline and truth of metaphysical interpretation.

HIGH**PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks**Paper I
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 10	Nature and stages of samadhi; role of Isvara.	Types of absorption and practical theism.
2023 / 15	Citta and its modifications; why cessation is prescribed.	Reflection, five vrttis, bondage.
2024 / 15	Appraise Yoga soteriology through citta-reflection and discrimination.	Klesa, practice, samadhi, kaivalya.
2025 / 15	Nature of God and role in kaivalya.	Special Purusa, Isvara-pranidhana, limits.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** define citta-vrtti-nirodha, classify the requested states, state Isvara's role, conclude on liberation.
- **15 marks:** trace klesa -> vrtti -> karma -> discipline -> samadhi -> kaivalya and add one philosophical objection.
- **20 marks:** reconstruct psychology and practice, compare Samkhya and Nyaya, assess whether meditative transformation validates dualism.
- **Applied drill:** Classify distraction during meditation as a citta-vrtti, identify its klesa support, and select the relevant limb of practice.
- **Applied drill:** Explain whether devotion to Isvara is indispensable or an optional powerful means within Patanjala Yoga.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Citta is consciousness itself.

CORRECT: Citta is a Prakriti-evolute reflecting Purusa. Core psychology.

WRONG: Yoga suppresses only bad thoughts.

CORRECT: All vrttis are ultimately restrained, including valid cognition. Explains nirodha.

WRONG: Isvara is the material creator.

CORRECT: Yoga defines a special Purusa chiefly relevant to practice. Avoid Nyaya/Vedanta import.

WRONG: Samadhi and kaivalya are identical.

CORRECT: Samadhi is the culminating means; kaivalya is final isolation. Preserve sequence.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
Citta is consciousness itself.	Citta is a Prakriti-evolute reflecting Purusa.	Core psychology.
Yoga suppresses only bad thoughts.	All vrttis are ultimately restrained, including valid cognition.	Explains nirodha.
Isvara is the material creator.	Yoga defines a special Purusa chiefly relevant to practice.	Avoid Nyaya/Vedanta import.
Samadhi and kaivalya are identical.	Samadhi is the culminating means; kaivalya is final isolation.	Preserve sequence.

MAINS ANGLE

Yoga offers the most systematic practical route in classical Indian philosophy, but its meditative achievements and dualist interpretation should be distinguished in critical evaluation.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.